

State Review Learnings:

Harding University

Alternative Route

On-Site Review: September 24–25, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

Harding University

Alternate Route

Overall Performance Level		
EXCEEDS		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
EXCEEDS	MEETS	EXCEEDS

Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion

Standard 1 Performance Level		
EXCEEDS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	EXCEEDS	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Harding University's alternative EPP has grown its enrollment well beyond the state target and effectively supports its students to complete the program.		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (i.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	Harding's annual plan for its alternative program is impressive in its willingness to be proactive in the continual improvement of the effectiveness of its program.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	14.2%	EXCEEDS

Enrollment

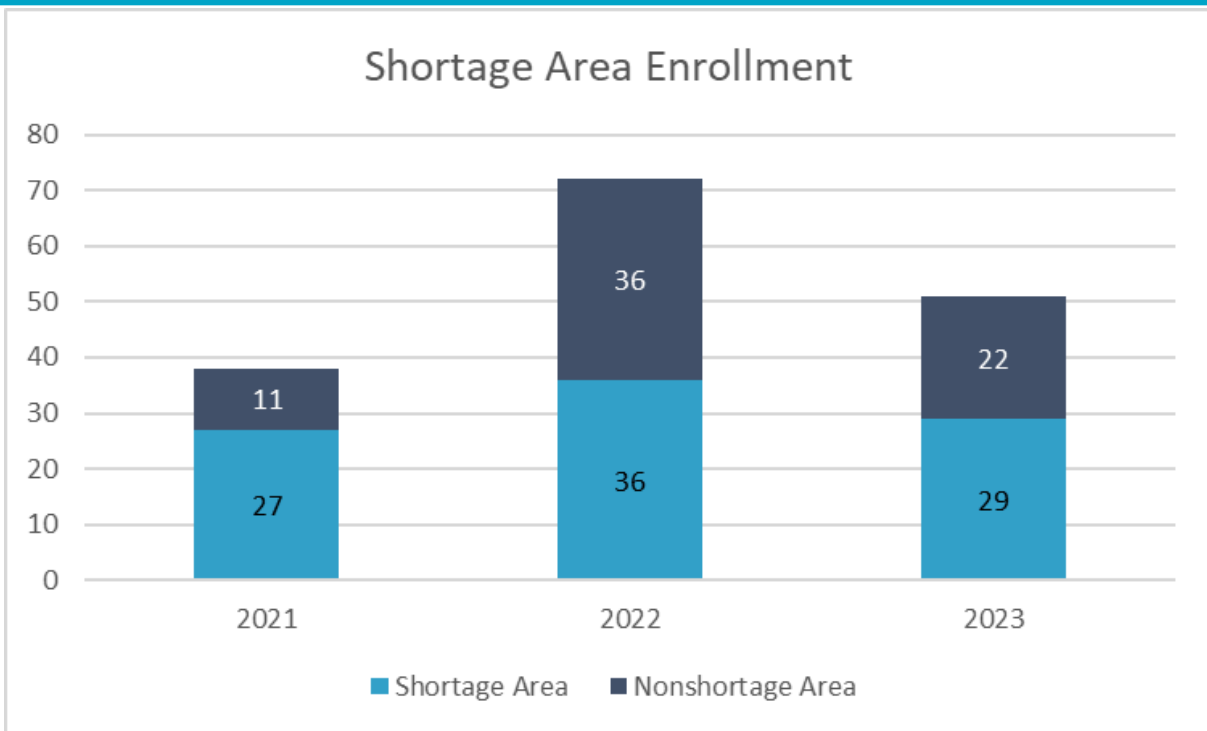
Metric is the percentage growth between blue and green boxes.

Year	Percentage Growth
2018	56
2019	50
2020	35
2021	38
2022	72
2023	51

*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a “Meets” rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an “Exceeds” rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	57%	EXCEEDS

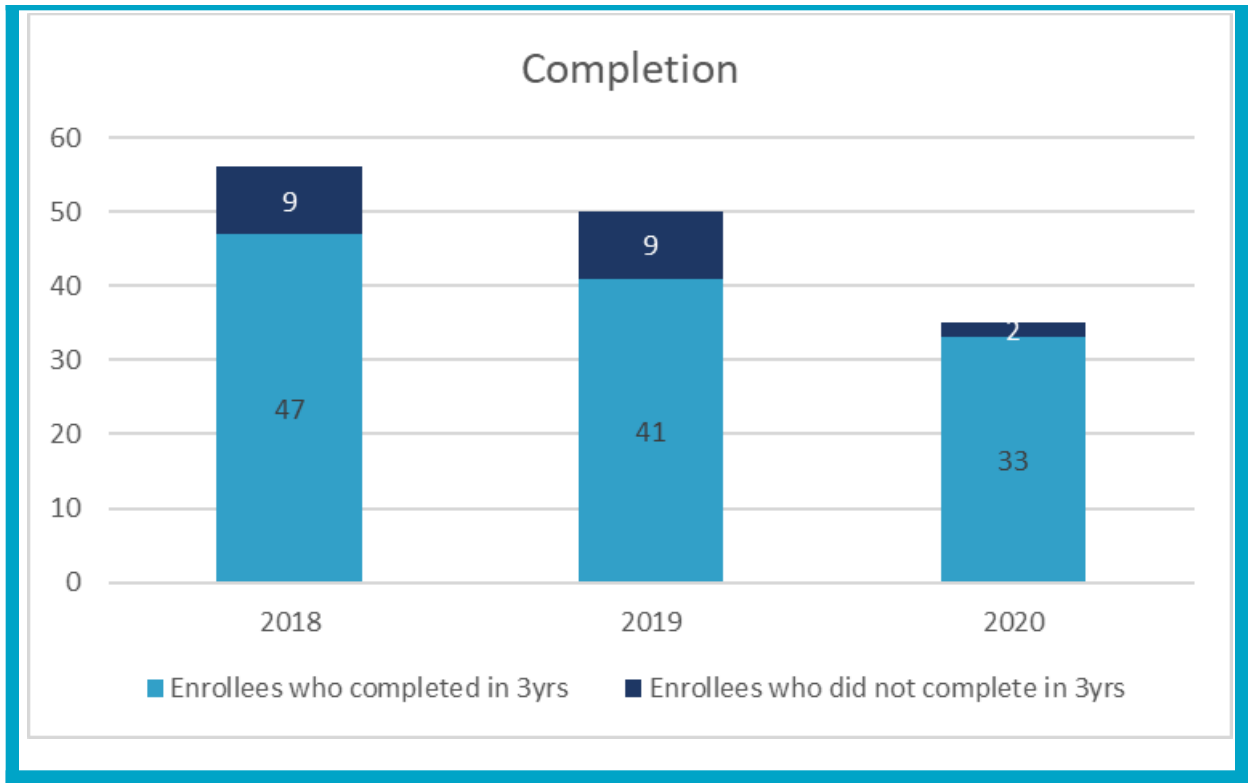
*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a "Meets" rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an "Exceeds" rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.



*Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline), demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased), and state focus areas. Current licensure areas of shortage: Computer Science (4-12), Biology (7-12), Chemistry (7-12), Physics (7-12), Foreign Language (K-12), Math (7-12), Math (4-8), Science (4-8), Special Education (K-12)

INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	86%	EXCEEDS



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS
Recommendations		
The alternative program at Harding University provided evidence to highlight their commitment to prepare teacher candidates to be day-one ready and provide continual support and feedback. Course instructors and clinical supervisors are a strength at Harding, utilizing best practices, Arkansas Teaching Standards and HQIM to prepare candidates. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation includes: • Document a clear and intentional process to fully support graduate students in their internship experience which includes opportunities to expose them to a variety of experiences especially for those candidates already in a teacher of record role. (Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2a Metric 2) • Formalize systems and structures to ensure that the mentor teachers and clinical supervisors working with candidates in the building are experienced, very effective and, by the 2026-2027 school year, have received DESE-recognized coaching training. (Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b)		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
MEETS
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction MEETS Coursework clearly incorporates nationally recognized best practices around content instruction, including recognizing and using high-quality instructional materials and evidence-based practices. Reviewers saw evidence of these practices in course syllabi, which highlighted the use of the following texts: Danielson Framework, Marzano New Art, Science of Reading, Uncovering the Logic of English, and others. Across programs, the Diverse Learners Project and Evidence of Student Learning projects are identified as major assignments. These assignments expect candidates to use best practices (high-quality research defined as peer-reviewed, published in the past five years, and a variety of sources, etc) to gain a greater understanding of the individual learner and use standards for lesson planning. Evidence was also seen in course observations. In Principles of Learning and Teaching (EDFD 6110), the instructor embedded HQIM practices and exposure to HQIM in coursework. Reviewers noted the rigor of expectation accelerates throughout the course. For example, teacher candidates begin with unpacking state standards and end with a standards-based unit plan that incorporates HQIM. The instructor also introduces formative and summative assessments, discusses differentiation, Marzano's high-yield strategies, and project-based learning

Focus group feedback reiterated the use of best practices. Both teacher candidates shared examples of using HQIM in their courses, with one participant discussing the use of a vocabulary board in an assignment that they then used in their own classroom, while the other shared that HQIM has been addressed in every class. One participant in the Course Instructor focus group shared, “Candidates engage with four HQIM in Literacy, using video and screencast models, and are trained to evaluate and adapt these materials using evidence-based strategies. Assignments are differentiated, offering candidates choice in how they demonstrate learning—even incorporating modalities like kinesthetic learning in online environments—while using consistent rubrics.”

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development

MEETS

Coursework familiarizes candidates with the Arkansas K-12 Academic Standards across all grade bands and provides opportunities for candidates to vertically integrate these standards. Reviewers identified multiple courses that familiarize teacher candidates with the standards, including EDFD 6110, MAT 6060, and ELED MLED 7-12, highlighting that unit assessment plans are aligned to standards.

In EDFD, reviewers observed assignments and assessments that incorporate K-12 standards. The instructor shared that students will group standards (for their grade level and content area) into units for the entire year. He said, “Even though it’s provided to them (when they begin teaching), I want them to understand the process.”

Teacher candidates agreed they are familiar with the standards, and they have assignments that require them to look across their grade level and to vertically integrate. One participant in the Coursework focus group said, “We made a pacing guide in our first introduction class to familiarize ourselves with the standards. I noticed there is an overlap, and as you go up, they become more complex, building on one another.”

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses

MEETS

Courses are sequenced to build off previous coursework. Reviewers noted that while the MAT program generally lacks a defined course sequence outside of the Residency, there are a few prerequisites, and course sequencing was observed in the Curriculum Plan, providing a strong foundation to be built upon.

Both Coursework focus group participants felt the sequence and progress of courses had been exceptionally clear and thoughtfully structured. One participant made a reference to the coursework as intertwining and building on one another, with recurring themes that deepen over time and reinforce the development of lessons, as well as ties to standards. For example, they shared the first course taken in the summer, “Introduction to Education,” which lays the groundwork for understanding teaching philosophies with lesson planning, and later courses challenged them to apply those principles in real-world planning and evaluation by building week-long content lesson plans

Course instructors agreed that there is a specific progression, sharing that most MAT candidates enter in the summer and begin with a foundational pedagogy course designed to introduce essential teaching practices. While not all receive it as their first class, it sets the stage for deeper learning. One instructor shared, “The rigor may not build across the program, but it does build within the course itself.” In Track 2, where candidates complete all coursework prior to residency, the sequence ensures they are well-prepared before entering classrooms, supported by required observation hours and field experiences, including those in classrooms and even church-based settings. For SPED candidates, the progression is highly intentional: the first course immerses them in the real-world context of special education—“They feel, touch, and see the paperwork and timelines”—while subsequent courses expand their understanding of how students may present across all 13 IDEA categories. This thoughtful progression supports both content mastery and applied practice, preparing candidates for effective instruction in diverse settings.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework

MEETS

Coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates the Arkansas Teaching Standards. In the documentation, reviewers found evidence that courses consistently addressed AR Teaching Standards, either by aligning with course objectives or through course assignments. Both English Language Structure for Teachers (RDNG 6450) and Literacy Strategies for

Beginning/Emerging Readers (SPED 6300) list the AR ELA Educator Competencies addressed in the course and align weekly course objectives to relevant AR Educator Competencies across relevant programs.

Course Instructors explained, “Standards are on the syllabi for each class,” and are reinforced through assignments that address “learner development, instructional strategies, learning differences, and assessment.” These standards are “all woven through the assignments,” including when candidates critique instructional videos or develop lesson plans. Additionally, candidates receive direct training on the Danielson Framework through TESS, where they “teach all of Domain 1, pieces of Domain 2, and are assessed in Domains 3 and 4.” Faculty emphasize that “if you are nailing TESS, you are doing ATS,” showing the alignment between instructional content and professional expectations. This intentional integration ensures candidates can create aligned, differentiated instruction and, as one instructor confidently noted, “Our MAT grads are day-one ready.”

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience

MEETS

Coursework is aligned to the clinical experience, and candidates have opportunities to reflect on the alignment with their course instructors and clinical supervisors. Nearly all (96%) of MAT teacher candidates work as teachers of record, allowing them to directly connect their coursework to their teaching experiences. Reviewers noted this alignment in course syllabi where teacher candidates are expected to complete a Field Notes journal each week and assignments that apply coursework to their practice.

In the Coursework focus group, one student said, “The alignment between coursework and clinical experience has been clear, intentional, and incredibly impactful in preparing me for the classroom. After the first class, I felt way more prepared than when I started.” Participants discussed their classroom management course, in particular, and how it helped them understand what to expect, how to interact with students, and how to navigate school policies—skills essential when they enter the classroom. They shared an observation course focused on exceptionalities, which required observation hours in SPED classrooms, providing both candidates with firsthand experience with IEPs and reinforcing the concepts taught in class. Both participants mentioned that they consistently reflect on these experiences with both clinical supervisors and course instructors, which helps them grow and understand how theory translates into practice.

During the Principles of Learning and Teaching (EDFD 6110) observation, the professor shared, “They leave (this course) with lesson planning, HQIM annotation, and course design. It is possibly the first time they have been exposed to theory. They choose their content area in the first week of the course, and in terms of assignments, they do their work around that.”

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of the standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy. Based on the documentation provided as evidence, there is one full-time and two adjunct faculty for the MAT program. All faculty have terminal degrees and evidence of continued professional development, including ATR and TESS training, coaching, and HQIM training.

One participant in the coursework focus group shared, “It feels like the professors know what they are doing. Many have been teachers; they have experience, and that makes me feel better about what I am learning.” All instructors in the Course Instructor focus group shared multiple professional developments they’ve participated in recently.

In the coursework observation for Interdisciplinary Literacy (SPED 6500), the professor shared that “the course is set up in modules and is set up where they have to go through every page. If they don’t, they won’t know the content.” The instructor provides a video each week outlining the week’s learning and assignments. Additionally, each week, candidates have a video of coursework content utilized in a classroom setting.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show evidence of strong facilitation, providing feedback and support. Faculty are evaluated yearly, which includes a faculty reflection and supervisor response addressing aspects of teaching, scholarship, and

service. In course evaluation data, all respondents rated their instructor as 4 (out of 5) or above relative to “faculty impact on students.”

Participants in the Coursework focus group agree that their instructors are effective facilitators and provide support when needed. One participant said, “They have been very helpful, and it’s more than a ‘good job’, they are very specific in what they tell us. I value the feedback I receive.” Another participant shared that their instructor facilitates coursework engagement, “We have required weekly discussions and instructors interact with those discussions too.”

Course observations also confirmed that instructors use multiple strategies to facilitate coursework and provide meaningful feedback. Assignments are designed in shared Google Docs to allow for ongoing formative feedback, while summative assessments are rubric-based and often include personalized comments. Faculty also provide synchronous support through Zoom or video feedback, with opportunities for resubmission when needed. One instructor described shifting the introduction of HQIM earlier in the program because “I noticed they need more foundation,” while another emphasized accessibility: “If they need extra support, we will Zoom.”

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

MEETS

The overall sequence of clinical experiences clearly builds off previous experiences and includes opportunities for learning and development. Reviewers noted the sequence in the documentation evidence, noting that both MAT tracks have coursework and clinical experiences, which allow students to apply specific course content. English Language Structure for Teachers (RDNG 6450) experience tutoring a student for 10 hrs and constructing a case study; SPED Methods (SPED 6060) experience creating a cumulative SPED paperwork packet, then, in Characteristics of Children with Exceptionalities (SPED 6210). candidates conduct an in-depth student study. Throughout their residency, the POP cycle documents demonstrate progressive knowledge in developing learner objectives, monitoring and supporting student growth, preparing cohesive instruction, and reflecting on practice.

Clinical Supervisors explained the sequence in the MAT program: “There are two tracks (in MAT). Ninety-five percent of our teacher candidates are in Track 1, working as the teacher of record. They start coursework as they are teaching, moving from para to lead, and may have experience in different school settings. In Track 2 (with 3 candidates this year), they complete all coursework first before entering the residency. Track 2 gets a lot of building through courses, using videos to experience different settings. Two other participants reiterated the use of quality videos as examples of different teaching and different environments.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

MEETS

The overall variety of clinical experiences provides opportunities for candidates to work with students with varied learning needs. MAT students complete a Diversity of Student Learning assignment aligned to the InTASC and Danielson frameworks. Six of the eight MAT courses require a minimum of 20 hours of field experiences, during which students apply course content while working with varied student populations. Finally, the placement demographic data indicate teacher candidates are working in schools with diverse populations, with 55% of placement locations falling into the low-socioeconomic designation.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus reinforced this. One participant shared that they are taking the SPED class this semester and will have observation hours, saying, “This is the first time I’ll have an experience outside of my teaching area.” Another participant shared they are “dealing with varying needs of students every day in my classroom. Having to scaffold. I’m in a reading class right now. I’m taking the modules we’re learning and applying them to my classroom right away.”

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers

MEETS

Most mentor teachers are equipped and demonstrate that they have the coaching skills to properly support and develop a teacher candidate. While documentation did not include a list of mentor teachers or their expertise, evidence was provided that shows Track 2 teacher candidates are placed by building administrators who pair them with experienced teachers. Track 1 candidates are employed under a provisional licensure and receive guidance and support from MAT program supervisors, as well as collaborate with another teacher in their building for additional support.

Clinical Supervisors and teacher candidates confirmed this in their focus groups. Clinical Supervisors said that MAT candidates are not (yet) required to have a mentor teacher, and all four participants in the Clinical Experience focus group shared that they do not have a mentor teacher, but they all have a teacher in their building who supports them.

Both superintendents in the School Partnership focus group noted that many mentor teachers hold or are pursuing Lead/Master designation, with additional coaching support offered in-house. One stated, “Many of ours have gone through cognitive coaching... we try to give them an extra skill set.”

Note: By 2026–2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. [Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual](#)

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers

MEETS

Program documents indicate that the MAT Residency Handbook outlines criteria for selecting mentor teachers, including years of classroom experience, instructional effectiveness, content expertise, and pedagogical knowledge. Selection occurs collaboratively between the MAT director and building administrators. While most MAT candidates serve as a teacher of record, there is a plan in place to select mentor teachers for any Track 2 MAT candidates who will complete a year of Residency.

In the superintendent focus group, both participants confirmed that their districts use processes—ranging from semi-formal to informal—to identify and match mentor teachers with teacher candidates. One superintendent explained, “The principals will help with a ‘pool’ of potential mentors, then the university selects. We offer a small stipend. It does become a little more competitive and evaluative.” The other added, “We seek input from the teacher who wants to be a mentor. Once HU lets us know what they’re seeking, we try to match up.” Both reported that the stipend is linked to Lead/Master teacher designation, which applies to most mentors, and emphasized that principals conduct regular evaluations through TESS observations and provide feedback to both mentors and candidates.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

MEETS

Most clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. Program documents, including the “MAT Handbook,” outline clear responsibilities for clinical supervisors, such as observing candidates at least four times per semester and holding conferences with both the mentor teacher and the teacher candidate. Evidence shows that clinical supervisors consistently provide feedback aligned with the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. Nearly all supervisors have extensive experience, with all but one having 18 or more years in teaching or administration, including district-level leadership.

In the teacher candidate focus group, participants described clinical supervisors as knowledgeable and supportive. One candidate shared, “I have had two supervisors; both stayed after class period and talked for an hour or more after observing me in the classroom; they made me feel that I was doing good as I was but helped me to grow.” Another candidate noted that their supervisors’ advice was “extremely helpful,” while others emphasized their availability and consistent communication, including weekly emails highlighting instructional domains.

Observations confirmed that clinical supervisors provided detailed, content-appropriate feedback connected to the ATR and Science of Reading rubrics. Clinical supervisors demonstrated effective coaching practices, such as offering positive reinforcement, asking reflective questions, and guiding candidates toward specific instructional improvements.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

MEETS

Candidates consistently receive high-quality feedback that is written and oral, connected to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, and linked to student learning. Program documents demonstrate that candidates receive frequent, high-quality feedback that is aligned with the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. Written feedback is captured through evaluations and Anthology, and oral recordings provide specific, rubric-linked comments such as, “In Domain 1e, it’s obvious in your planning that you’re connecting what was learned in the past to what is being learned today,” and “You went ‘duh-eh-duh’...That’s ok. We all do it. You’ll get used to clipping the sound.” Student assessment data is also tracked and shared with candidates to reinforce the connection between feedback and student learning outcomes.

In the Clinical Experience focus group, participants consistently described receiving written and oral feedback that built on prior observations. One candidate explained, “If I build on the feedback that they’ve already given to me, then we move on, but if I haven’t built on it, they will give reminders that it’s something we’re working on.” Another noted, “I always get written feedback... Last year, I didn’t know all my students’ names, and I received feedback on that. I thought about it all year, and now I know all my students’ names.” Candidates emphasized that feedback was targeted, practical, and contributed to their professional growth.

Observations confirmed that supervisors provided detailed, ATR-aligned coaching that connected directly to evidence of student learning. Feedback included both affirmations and targeted next steps, such as: “You created an atmosphere of excitement. Talk about the students’ behavior and procedures,” and “Looking at the structure for learning, I love how you popcorned around for questions. It keeps them focused and engaged.” Clinical supervisors encouraged reflection and emphasized continuous improvement, reinforcing that feedback was consistent, high-quality, and built on prior performance.

Note: The Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by EPPs by the 2024–25 academic year.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

MEETS

Collaborative processes are in place with most districts/schools to co-construct the clinical internship for candidates, evidenced by the agenda for the “Searcy Governance Meeting” attended by the MAT director, school administrators, and mentor teachers. This document highlights discussion items, such as providing more opportunities for candidates to practice classroom management in real settings and giving residents access to district HQIM.

In focus groups, both the school district and EPP expressed high regard for the partnership. The schools said they consider Harding University’s program as a pipeline for quality teachers in their districts. School partner leadership is actively working to create a pathway for compensation for residents working in its school district. Both parties elaborated on the ease of communication between them, from calling on cell phones, emails, and school visits. They meet every semester to review the quality of feedback and discuss future needs for teacher candidates.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

Collaborative processes are consistently in place that support and develop effective clinical supervisors through training and communication, such as sessions to align expectations, evaluations, and feedback strategies. The document “CS Meeting for MAT program” reviews responsibilities, including the ATR, POP cycles, and training. Almost all clinical supervisors have completed cognitive coaching training and aspiring teacher training, and several have content-specific training..

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

MEETS

Most candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. The Residency Handbook establishes performance criteria for continuing in the program, including a minimum GPA requirement. The “Semester GPA tracker” shows data for the last three semesters, indicating the average cumulative GPA is above 3.5 in all semesters.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

MEETS

Candidates are provided with an individualized support plan if their coursework is not on track. A “Candidate Improvement Plan” is in place, as outlined in the “MAT Residency Handbook,” that requires candidates to co-create strategies for improvement. Candidate performance in coursework is tracked, and grades of “C” and below are flagged. A calendar of reminders to candidates regarding key requirements and deadlines demonstrates active support for candidates.

Course Instructors agreed there are supports in place for struggling candidates. In the focus group, they commented that all coursework is online, so accommodations for individualized support are made through both synchronous and asynchronous contact with students. One instructor described how specific videos are chosen to meet the needs of individual students to strengthen their opportunities to observe best practice outside of the areas they teach. Instructors mentioned being available to meet individually whenever candidates needed additional support.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

MEETS

Programs have a clear set of goals and milestones, and most candidates meet these milestones. Program gates are clearly outlined in the MAT Residency Handbook. A system for candidate data tracking demonstrates that residents meet goals as reflected by scores on performance evaluations, diversity of student learning, and evidence of student learning.

One participant in the Clinical Experience focus group said, “They (Harding) were very good about giving me the whole checklist that I need to complete. Projects and observations... I have three projects to complete this semester.” Clinical Supervisors confirmed the goals and milestones outlined in the residency course and said, “We do not hear a lot of ‘I don’t know what I’m supposed to do.’ They do very well.”

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

MEETS

There is adequate evidence that candidates have the capacity to impact student growth. Reviewers saw evidence of candidates utilizing student assessments in supervisor feedback on the ATR, noting that candidates are routinely demonstrating effective planning for assessing student learning (TESS 1f).

One candidate in the Clinical Experience focus group shared, “We use ATLAS to gather data on the kids and use formal and summative assessments. This assignment in particular can check their data and scaffold as needed.” One clinical supervisor referenced an assignment that required candidates to identify three different students at varying levels (advanced, grade level, struggling), identify a lesson, collect data, teach, and follow up with a post assessment to determine student growth and learning.”

Reviewers also noted conversations between the teacher candidates and their clinical supervisor during coaching observations. They highlighted one conversation: the supervisor asked the candidate, “Do you gather any data about the progression of the students? Do you talk with the coach about your data?” The candidate articulated how he uses data to foster student growth and plan his instruction/activities.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Most candidates receive a score of “effective” on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. Candidates were observed and assessed four times throughout a semester. Every candidate had a positive trajectory, including those who initially scored below the 3.0 expectation. Mean scores on the final Aspiring Teacher Evaluation in 2024–25 averaged 3.34 across all domains, with 49 of 52 (94%) candidates scoring a three or higher.

A sample candidate tracking report demonstrates that progress is tracked by the clinical supervisor and that in the sample provided, all candidates scored at effective or higher.

Note: By 2024–25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship MEETS

All candidates with varied learning needs are provided the support they need. Documentation highlights the use of a “Resident Improvement Plan” to help struggling candidates (MAT Residency Handbook). This formal process includes discussions between the candidate, clinical supervisor, mentor teacher, MAT Director and school administrator. The “Candidate Support for Off-Track Residents” documents four specific examples of improvement plan discussions and outcomes. In addition to the formal process, candidates receive regular feedback based on the ATR during observations.. Comments were stated positively while targeting areas for improvement: “You covered the objectives at the first of the lesson. You gave the agenda for class. You might consider introducing visitors to the class and letting them know why they are there.”

Both teacher candidates in the Clinical Experience focus group agreed they felt supported, saying they could ask for support any time they needed it.

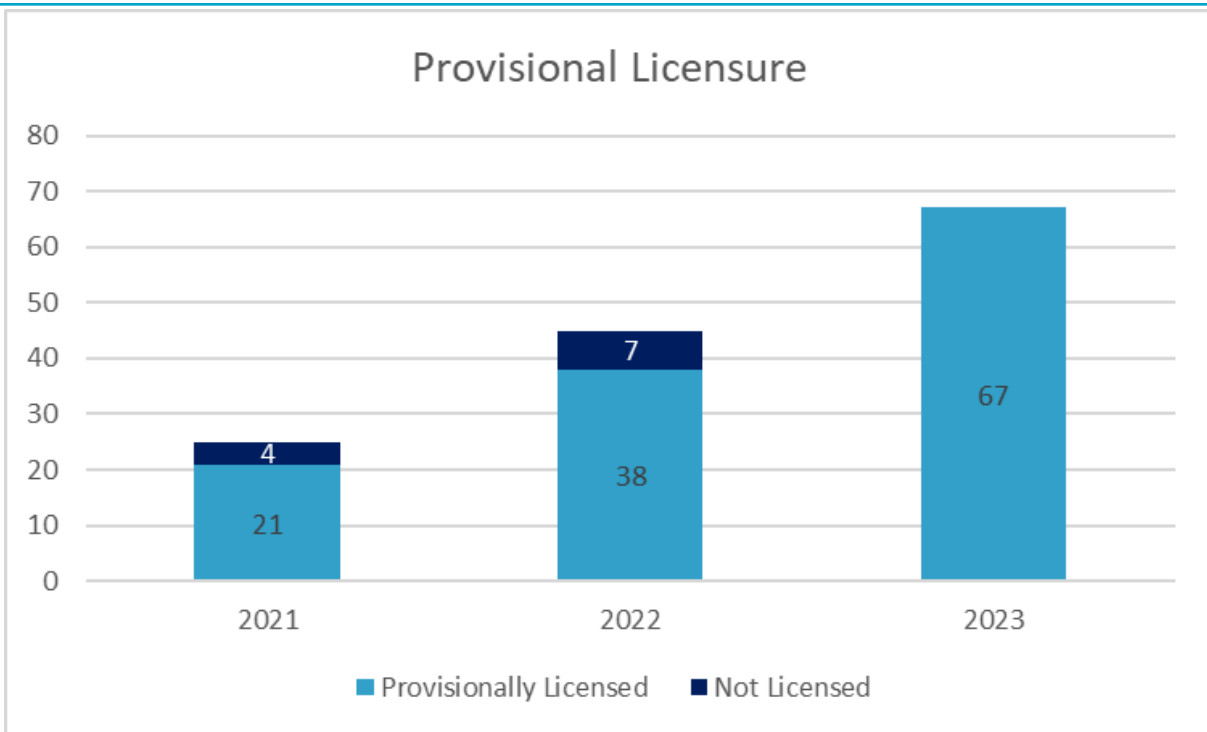
Most high-performing candidates receive opportunities and feedback that encourage their retention. Clinical supervisors encourage their teacher candidates to take on leadership roles in their schools, such as coaching, committee memberships, etc. One supervisor said, “Your experience and performance allow you to gain opportunities, adding to committees and leadership positions.”

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
EXCEEDS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
MEETS	EXCEEDS	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Harding’s alternative route program meets or exceeds nearly all of the State’s targets for EPPs to support Arkansas’s workforce needs, including completers who become licensed, work in Arkansas public schools and districts (including priority districts and subjects), and stay in the classroom for multiple years. Recommendations include: Continue to review EPP Completer Supervisor Survey and EPP Completer Survey results to identify specific domains and components for which both supervisors and candidates do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3a and 3.3b</i>)		

INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level												
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license within one year of completion	80%	79%	MEETS												
Licensure <table><thead><tr><th>Year</th><th>Licensed</th><th>Not Licensed</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>2021</td><td>38</td><td>5</td></tr><tr><td>2022</td><td>34</td><td>12</td></tr><tr><td>2023</td><td>53</td><td>16</td></tr></tbody></table>				Year	Licensed	Not Licensed	2021	38	5	2022	34	12	2023	53	16
Year	Licensed	Not Licensed													
2021	38	5													
2022	34	12													
2023	53	16													
Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level												
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	73%	92%	EXCEEDS												



Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	66%	N/A	N/A

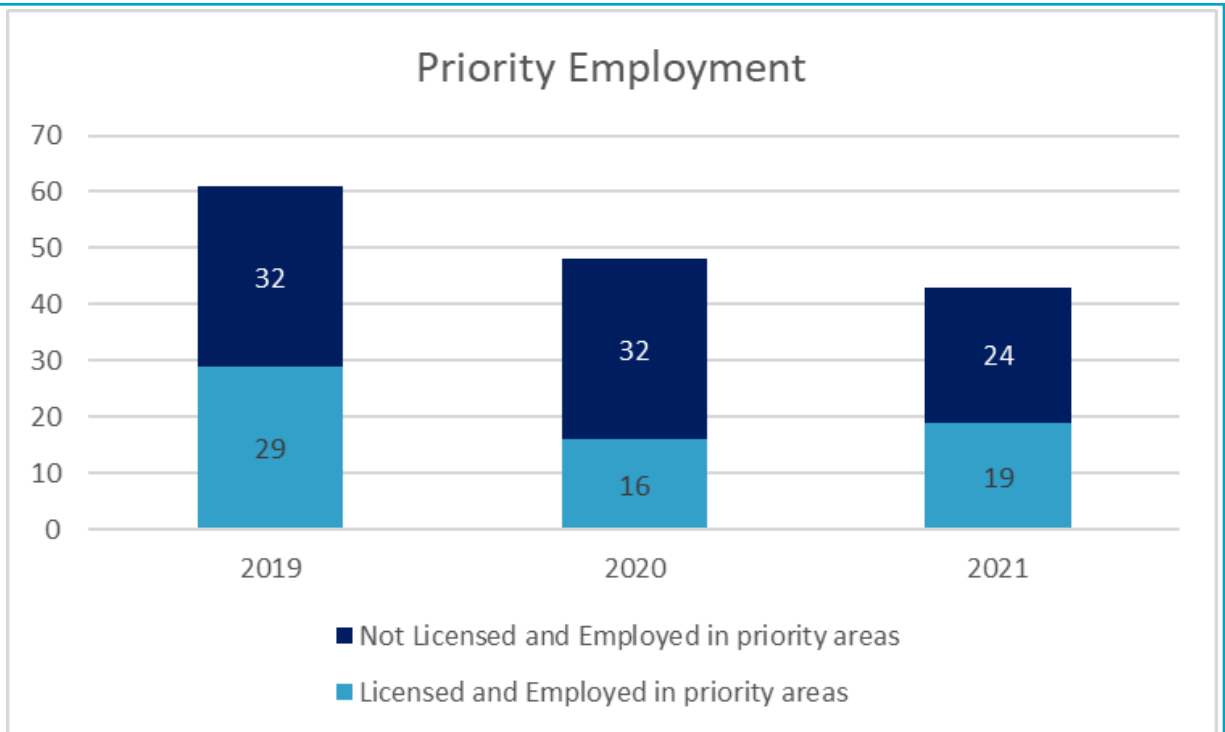
INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	68%	75%	EXCEEDS

Employment

Year	Licensed and Employed	Not Licensed and Employed
2019	45	16
2020	38	10
2021	31	12

Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	38%	42%	EXCEEDS



*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

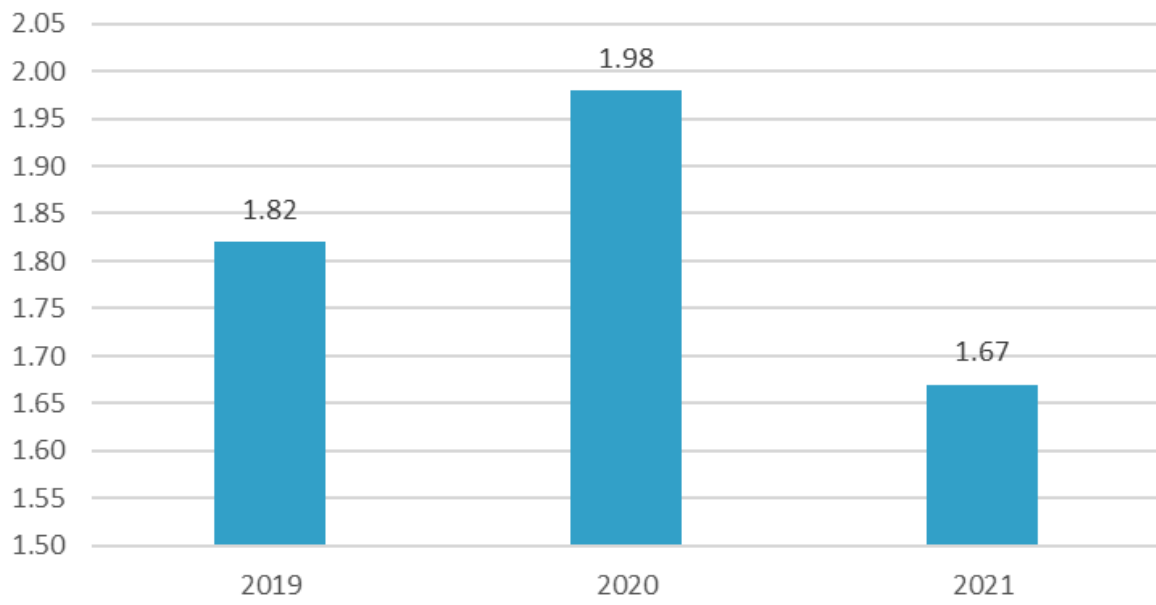
Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.77	1.83	EXCEEDS

Average Experience 3 Years After Completion



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	78%	80%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	79%	86%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	53%	EXCEEDS

